

10 April '20

10/4/20

A Photograph

- Shirley Toulson

The poet deals with the theme of the impermanence of life, death and decay are integral part of human life with time man loses his youth and strength and then one day he is no more. What is left behind are the sweet and sour memories which are often evoked by same photograph. The realities of changes and death have to be accepted.

Word Meanings:

- 1 Paddling - walking through shallow water bare-feet.
- 2 Terribly - Horribly
- 3 Transient - Temporary
- 4 laboured - day of labour
- 5 Ease - easy
- 6 Circumstance - any situation
- 7 dry - disappointment

Key-Points:

- * The poet looks at an old photograph of her mother's childhood.
- * The mother is standing on the beach with her two cousins enjoying their time near the sea.
- * Years later the poet's mother just laugh recalling that childhood moment.
- * Now the mother is no more and the poet feels her absence deeply.
- * The photograph becomes a source of nostalgia and grief.
- * The poem highlights how life can change but nature remain constant.
- * The scene remains unchanged symbolizing eternity and continuity.
- * It ends with poet's silence showing that grief is beyond words.

Poetic Devices:-

- 1 Allusion: Indirect reference to the person, place, or etc.
Ex -
- 2 Alliteration: Terribly transient feet, silence
silences

3 Oxymoron: Labour'd ease

4 Personification: silence silences

5 Transferred Epithet: Transient feet. (Used to describe lack of permanence in human life)

I Multiple Choice Questions:-

Q1 What does the cardboard depict?

- (a) A scenery
- (b) Picture of a house
- (c) Picture of a school
- (d) Three girls (✓)

Q2 Who is the 'Big Girl' mentioned here?

- (a) The poet herself
- (b) The poet's mother (✓)
- (c) The poet's friend
- (d) The poet's daughter

II Short Answer Questions:-

Q1 The poet's mother would love looking at the photo. why?

Ans She loved the photo because it captured her carefree childhood moment at the beach with her cousin, reminding her of innocence, joy, and laughter - contrasting with the responsibilities of adulthood. It was a nostalgic link to her happy past.

Q2 The poet talks about a particular cardboard. How is it special to her?

Ans The "cardboard" is special because it holds the old photograph of her mother's childhood at the beach. For the poet, it symbolized memory, nostalgia, and the permanence of captured joy against the impermanence of life, making it emotionally priceless.

Q3 Explain 'its silence silences'.

Ans "Its silence silences" means the photograph, though mute, conveys deep grief. Its quietness reflects the mother's absence, leaving the poet speechless. The still image contrasts with living voices, emphasizing loss - silence of the photo intensified the silence of the poet's heart.

III Long Answers

Q1 The sea appears to have changed less in comparison to the three girls who enjoyed the holiday. Comment.

Ans The sea, in the poem, is described as eternal and unchanged, while the three girls in the photograph have aged and one has passed away. This contrast highlights the permanence of nature versus the transience of human life. The sea's timelessness intensifies the poet's sense of loss, showing how human joy and existence fade, but nature remains constant. It underscores the theme of impermanence and the inevitability of change in human lives, while natural elements endure across generations.

Shiv
22/11/24

W.S.